

Episode 203: Happy New Year – Promotional Special!

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Happy New Year! How is everyone spending this 2014 New Year?

I truly apologize for consecutive breaks at year-end. I don't know how many people look forward to my series, but hmm, sorry.

Looking back, the first break was due to influenza - in my memory, the last time I had flu was in middle school, so it was flu after 30-odd years. Thanks to that I had to leave the work site for a week, and that burden hit the following week! Furthermore, the production situations of works I was involved in kept piling up under pressure, so from the illness break I continued taking series breaks through year-end.

So the works I was creating at the sacrifice of such series (sweat) are finally appearing before everyone starting this month.

First, an OVA work. I'm participating in Director Sato Junichi's original new work *Critically Endangered Girl: Amazing Twins* as colour design (visual coordinate). This work is being created centered on the production staff from *Kaleido Star*, which aired exactly 10 years ago. Director: Sato Junichi, Character Design: Oizaki Fumitoshi (追崎史敏), Production: Encourage Films. The cast is also supported by *Kaleido* members. *Kaleido Star*, which had a complete rerun in Kanto local last autumn and incredibly has Blu-ray Box release decided this year - for those *Kaleido Star* fans, "Kaleido idiots" - we're working hard with "Deliver!"

It's a 2-volume OVA. Release starts from February, but the first volume was already unveiled at year-end with advance screenings and advance distribution beginning. And work on the second volume is already proceeding steadily.

TV work. *Witch Craft Works* has already started broadcasting. It's an anime adaptation of the same-name comic serialised in "Monthly good! Afternoon." Director is Mizushima Tsutomu. Character Design is Hiyamizu Yukie (冷水由紀絵), Colour Design is Ishida Miyuki. Production is J.C.Staff.

For this work I'm participating with the credit "Visual Coordinate" (also credited along with colour design in the aforementioned *Critically Endangered Girl: Amazing Twins*). What exactly is this Visual Coordinate role? It's a supervisory role for overall visuals, perhaps. Centered on the colour aspects I've been involved with, it's a role of bringing together series-wide image creation and visual direction.

Specifically what am I doing? I participate in each episode's image creation from meetings between the director and individual episode directors, contributing various ideas while organising and adjusting visual direction. What I'm aiming for is work creation where all sections can share completion screen images from the beginning, so we don't end up with footage that results from assembly-line work. For that, I participate in all meetings - art, colour, 3D, photography - contributing many opinions and checking things that come from each. It's quite hard (laugh).

This is a credit I've been using since the theatrical *One Piece Film Z* the year before last. Then last year's *Hakkenden: Eight Dogs of the East*, and now *Witch Craft Works*. For *One Piece Film Z* and *Hakkenden* it was "Visual Coordinate" on top of doing all the "colour design" work, but this time we have a separate colour designer. I handled colour design for main characters, but based on that, Ishida skillfully handled the rest. That's how we're making *Witch Craft Works*.

And one more work. *Wake Up, Girls!* A success story of idol unit "Wake Up, Girls!" formed in Tohoku's Sendai gradually, gradually growing. Original Plan & Director: Yamamoto Yutaka, Character Design: Chikaoka Tadashi (近岡直). I'm credited as colour design, but I'm doing various things here too. Production is Ordet×Tatsunoko Pro.

This is also tough - first there's the theatrical *Wake Up, Girls! Seven Idols* depicting their birth as Episode "0," opening Friday January 10th. Also from January 10th, the TV series depicting their activities (?) starts broadcasting. Man, this double attack final push got me over year-end New Year (cry).

This project actually formed idol unit Wake Up, Girls! through auditions, and those 7 members actually voice the characters. Man, I never imagined I'd participate in an idol work! Along with *Gundam*, I thought it was one of the most distant things from me (laugh).

At the recent theatrical version completion screening, seeing the girls get moved almost to tears on stage after watching the main story for the first time at the venue, this old man was completely affected too! (laugh) So the growth of the real Wake Up, Girls! and the story's Wake Up, Girls! seven overlap in a mysteriously strange experience.

These are my first jobs of 2014. Everyone, please support them!

(14.01.10)